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THE BJP AS THE PARTY OF THE VILLAGE

An Introduction

How many people didn't get a toilet in this village? Raise your hands,' said UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on the microphone. It was late night in Kandhai Madhopur village in central Uttar Pradesh's Pratapgarh district. The chief minister was sitting under a banyan tree, legs dangling off the edge of a large, specially constructed saffron stage. He was surrounded by over 3,000 villagers, some of whom had climbed trees and rooftops to get a better glimpse of him. An angry chorus rose from the crowd as several hands went up. Yogi leant into the mike again, asking, 'Who is the DPRO [District Panchayati Raj Officer] here?'

The officer, standing amidst a row of apparatchiks on the stage, stepped up gingerly, saying within earshot of the crowd, 'Five hundred toilets have been approved this year, sir. Fifty, last year.'

'Note this,' responded Yogi to him on the mike. 'And you note it too,' he said, looking meaningfully at the crowd. 'By tomorrow all labharthees should get the money into their bank account. If it doesn't reach the bank accounts, then accountability will be fixed.'

He moved on to his second public question. 'How many ration cards have been made in this village?' Again, a cacophony of responses from the gathered crowd. Yogi gestured to the row of officers nearby. 'Where is the DPRO, CDO [Chief Development Officer], DM [District Magistrate]? All three can come up here.' As